

Program Learning Summaries: Applying Business Education to Consulting

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Abstract

My business education has helped me connect leadership experience with more deliberate approaches to organizational planning, evidence evaluation, resource allocation, and data analysis. This reflection examines four courses: BUSN100, Basics of Business; PHIL110, Critical Thinking; ECON201, Microeconomics for Business; and BUSN250, Analytics I. Each course summary connects four learning objectives to specific coursework and explains how those skills support my goal of providing business, people, and strategy consulting. Examples include a consulting-firm business playbook, a two-factor authentication policy, a rhetorical-device analysis, an argument presentation about responsible artificial intelligence use, and economics papers addressing specialization and housing affordability. The analytics reflection describes learning to date through spreadsheet, PivotTable, and descriptive-statistics work. Together, these experiences demonstrate how I can organize recommendations, question assumptions, and connect operational decisions with evidence. They also identify areas for continued development and artifacts that can communicate my professional capabilities to prospective employers and consulting clients.

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The four courses selected for this reflection represent capabilities I would emphasize in an interview: understanding business operations, evaluating arguments, applying economic reasoning, and using data to support decisions. These capabilities strengthen the experience I developed during 22 years in the Marine Corps and later roles in operations, instruction, nonprofit leadership, and business ownership. Each summary addresses four course objectives, identifies supporting coursework, and connects the learning to my goal of advising leaders on people, performance, and strategy execution.

BUSN100: Basics of Business

BUSN100 helped me connect individual management decisions with the needs of an entire business. Its objectives address the business environment, economic conditions, organizational structures, and technology (American Public University System [APUS], 2024a). I would highlight this course because the assignments show how I convert broad concepts into practical, measurable recommendations.

For CO-1, describing the business environment, I created an Entrepreneur's Playbook for the proposed Fidelis Strategic Consulting Group (Williams, 2026b). I examined credibility, competition, changing client needs, and service quality across business lifecycle stages. In practice, I would test credibility-building efforts through lead-to-client conversion, client retention, and repeat engagements rather than rely on activity counts alone.

For CO-2, explaining how economic conditions affect performance, I considered declining consulting demand during a downturn and proposed workshops, retainers, and subscription-based leadership development. These options could create a more stable revenue mix. Management could compare recurring-revenue share, monthly revenue variance, and

renewal rates before and after the change to determine whether diversification improved resilience.

For CO-5, explaining internal structures, I proposed defined departments, reporting relationships, standard procedures, and a possible transition from a centralized hierarchy to a matrix structure. Clear ownership could reduce handoff delays and rework while protecting service quality. Turnaround time, on-time delivery, error rates, and client satisfaction would show whether the new structure improved accountability.

For CO-8, describing technology's business impact, I wrote a Two-Factor Authentication Policy with phased enrollment, support, verification, and consequences for noncompliance (Williams, 2026d). The project showed that a technical control also needs understandable instructions and implementation measures. Enrollment completion, exception-closure time, help-desk volume, and unauthorized-access incidents could show whether security improved without unnecessary operational friction.

PHIL110: Critical Thinking

PHIL110 strengthened my ability to examine the reasoning behind a recommendation instead of accepting a confident presentation at face value. The course emphasizes logical analysis, argument reconstruction, rhetorical devices, and sound argument development (APUS, 2024b). These skills matter because leaders need recommendations they can question, understand, and defend before committing resources.

For CO-1, explaining critical thinking and logical analysis, I created a fictional Brain Shield advertisement and examined how persuasive language could make unsupported claims sound credible (Williams, 2025b). Producing both the advertisement and reflection taught me to separate persuasion from justification. In client work, I can require evidence, define assumptions, and compare promised results with verified performance.

For CO-3, analyzing reasoning through reconstruction and diagrams, my final presentation mapped an argument about responsible AI use in higher education (Williams, 2026a). The diagram connected the thesis with accessibility, adaptive learning, faculty support, a counterargument, and a response. The same method can shorten decision review by exposing evidence gaps; revision cycles, unresolved risks, and approval time can measure improvement.

For CO-4, analyzing rhetorical devices and pseudo-reasoning, I identified appeals to authority and fear in the Brain Shield script. Unnamed specialists and warnings about deception created pressure without proving effectiveness. That analysis strengthened my ability to challenge unsupported vendor claims and emotionally driven proposals while still examining legitimate concerns and the evidence needed to resolve them.

For CO-5, producing an argument free from logical errors, I organized the AI presentation around a conditional thesis, supporting reasons, and safeguards for academic-integrity concerns. I argued for oversight and transparent use rather than automatic adoption. An organizational policy based on this reasoning could be evaluated through disclosure compliance, documented reviews, policy violations, and accessibility outcomes.

ECON201: Microeconomics for Business

ECON201 provided a framework for explaining how scarce resources, incentives, and market conditions shape business decisions. Its objectives connect microeconomic theory with business applications, allocation choices, supply and demand, and market barriers (APUS, 2022). I would highlight this course because my papers linked economic concepts with construction, nonprofit operations, and housing affordability.

For LO-1, applying microeconomic theory to business, my Division of Labor paper examined how specialization improves production (Williams, 2025a). I used fence construction tasks such as measuring, setting posts, cutting lumber, and assembling panels. A redesigned

workflow could be tested through cycle time, schedule adherence, rework, and labor hours per project to determine whether specialization improved throughput and quality.

For LO-3, explaining resource-allocation problems, I analyzed overlapping responsibilities in youth programs and the opportunity costs facing housing buyers and developers (Williams, 2026c). Clearer role allocation could reduce duplicated effort and uncovered work. Staffing coverage, overtime, service delays, and budget variance would show whether limited labor, time, money, and land were being used more effectively.

For LO-4, applying supply and demand, my housing paper examined how limited land and long construction timelines constrain supply while borrowing costs affect purchasing decisions. I learned that slower price growth does not necessarily mean improved affordability. Permit lead time, project backlog, financing cost, and completed-unit volume would connect market analysis with capacity and pricing decisions.

For LO-7, examining market entry and exit, I analyzed zoning, permitting, and infrastructure as barriers to housing development. Demand alone does not establish whether a firm can serve a market profitably or quickly. A staged entry plan could use decision gates based on permitting time, infrastructure readiness, expected margin, and demand conversion before management commits full resources.

BUSN250: Analytics I

BUSN250 is helping me turn operational observations into information that supports decisions. The course connects organizational data, spreadsheet elements, descriptive calculations, and interpretation (APUS, 2020). Because the course is still in progress, this reflection addresses my learning to date. I would discuss it as evidence of developing analytical skill alongside leadership and training experience.

For CO-1, distinguishing data, information, and knowledge, my PivotTable discussion used employee-training records as a workplace example. Completion entries are data; summarized completion rates provide information; comparing completion with assessment and performance results supports knowledge. Linking completion, scores, observed performance, and error trends could help leaders distinguish attendance from capability and target additional support.

For CO-2, comparing spreadsheet data elements, my spreadsheet and PivotTable work required consistent categories, numerical values, and source records. I examined completion status, assessment scores, Excel Tables, and refreshed summaries. Reliable structures reduce outdated reports and classification errors. Refresh dates, missing values, duplicate records, and reconciliation differences provide practical data-quality checks before management acts.

For CO-3, calculating descriptive statistics, my Week 4 exercise used odd integers from 1 through 29. The mean and median were both 15. Replacing 29 with 100 increased the mean to about 19.73 while the median stayed 15. Using AVERAGE and MEDIAN connected spreadsheet functions with a concrete demonstration of an outlier's effect.

For CO-7, interpreting descriptive statistics at work, the exercise showed why one unusual observation can change an average without changing the middle value. Comparing mean, median, range, and outliers can prevent one extreme case from distorting a training or project-cost report. This supports more accurate conclusions and directs corrective action toward the process or case producing the exception.

Conclusion

Together, these courses show a progression from understanding organizations to communicating evidence-based recommendations. BUSN100 connected structure and technology with business needs; PHIL110 strengthened evaluation of claims; ECON201 clarified

resource and market trade-offs; and BUSN250 developed workplace-data interpretation. The revised measures make each recommendation testable and reinforce my goal of helping leaders convert analysis into responsible action.

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